

Custom Menus

Some programs include menus that are somewhat different from the normal pull-down menus. A good example is the Color menu in the Finder (Figure 5D). Pulling it down reveals not a list of colors, but the colors themselves in a five-by-three grid. You select a color from this menu the same way you'd select an item from a regular menu, except you can move the pointer sideways. Some other programs—like HyperStudio—display small icons for their tools in similar menus.

Tear-off menus are gaining popularity. In some programs, like HyperCard GS, you can detach a menu from a menu bar and leave it lying on the screen. This is especially useful with pull-down color menus and tool menus. Once menus are torn off, they become windoids which look and behave somewhat like regular windows except that they stay in front of any other windows on the screen. (Don't worry, we'll explain windows and windoids in due course.) You can then select an item from the torn-off menu simply by clicking on it, and you can move it around the screen wherever you want. You can dismiss the menu by clicking the windoid's close box.

To tear off such a menu, pull it down as usual. Then drag the pointer outside the menu. An outline of the menu will follow the pointer. Release the mouse button and the menu appears on your screen where you dragged it. Remember, this trick doesn't work in all programs, just the ones which are specifically designed to support it.

Note!

The Finder's Color menu does not tear off. Attempting to do so will only make you feel silly.

Hierarchical menus are used frequently on the Macintosh but are rarely seen on the IIGS. In fact, we only know of one program that uses them, and neither the IIGS nor System 6 support them directly, so you probably won't see very many of them. But nevertheless, if you see a rightward-pointing arrowhead to the right of a menu item, you'll know you're about to encounter a hierarchical menu. When you highlight that menu item, a second menu will "pop up" to the right of the arrowhead. Slide the pointer into this submenu and select an item from there (or move the pointer back into the pull-down menu to get rid of the pop-up menu).

Alerts & Dialogs

Using Alerts

Alert windows (or just "alerts") appear when something unexpected has happened to find out what you intend to do about it. Take, for example, Figure 5E, where we have foolishly told the computer to move the program "Teach" into a folder which already contains a program by that name. (Well, actually, we might have meant to do that. Alerts don't necessarily mean you've made a mistake.) In any case, the computer doesn't know whether or not we meant to replace the existing "Teach" program, so it asks us to confirm our action before erasing the old file.